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Walking It Off

This was - mercifully - the last in a series of five league events held here in Australia. I appreciate the beauty and hospitality of the Land Down Under, but seriously... I was getting sick of this place. That said, there was an additional perk to this particular trip.

While the autumn months were blowing in back home, spring was in full bloom here in Perth, and the cool, crisp air was ideal for a late night stroll.

I walked out the main door onto Wellington Street and turned right for no particular reason. Then I started walking. I didn't know where I was going. I just had to go.

I hadn't even gone a block when my phone chirped. A text from Steph. No message. Just a link, that took me to a video.

Cheryl Cole's press conference.

As soon as I realized what it was I thought, *What the hell could that bitch possibly have said now?*

But, no... it was nothing like that. Cole might be arrogant as hell, but she wasn't stupid. She could not deny reality. Danni was better than she was. Her fight plan revealed that she knew that long before the opening bell, yet Danni had beaten her anyway. There was no way to get around those facts without looking like an idiot.

So Cheryl took it on the chin... freely admitting that Danni was the rightful champion. She was then asked if she was worried about defending her division title against the rejuvenated Ms. Harris. That brought another startling admission. She was... and she knew she had a lot of work to do if she had any hope.

It was both unbelievable and unsurprising at the same time. Cole was subdued and humble throughout. Nothing like the egotistical braggart she'd been before. Not because she'd changed, but because Danni had literally beaten the swagger out of her. Her body language said it all. Slumped in the chair, eyes downcast, shoulders sagging... it was a beautiful sight, and I found myself trying to pick out the best moment to print and frame so I could give it to Danni as a gift.

I smiled as I slipped the phone back in my pocket and walked on.

I would figure it out later. Cheryl had given me plenty of options to choose from.

I passed *Princess Margaret Children's Hospital* and a soccer stadium called the *Subiaco Oval*. I followed the walkway around the stadium and headed north over a set of train tracks that disappeared into a tunnel beneath me. Then came *St. John of God* hospital - which prominently featured a cancer center geared toward children and left me wondering exactly how many sick kids they had in this area.

I was considering which way to go next when my phone rang.

"Where are you?" Danni asked.

"I told you I was going out for a walk."

A beat or two passed as she realized what I'd meant by *out*.

"Wait, you actually left the building?"

"Mmm, hmm," I hummed. "I'm literally wandering aimlessly around the city."

Several more seconds ticked by.

"Are you OK?"

"I'm fine," I said, and for the first time in a long time, I actually was.

She didn't respond and I could sense her struggle.

On the one hand, she was worried because I was acting like a loon. I had literally gone on walkabout. Obviously, I'd spent too much time here in the Australian sun.

But there was a giddiness in my voice that gave her pause. I heard it myself, and I couldn't have stopped it if I wanted to.

And why would I not be giddy?

The rookies were not only on the right track, but they'd put their stamp on things in the most emphatic way I could think of. Not only meeting the challenge, but tacitly issuing one of their own. Seemed to me they were prepared to back it up, too.

My stable was humming along on a level I didn't know could be achieved, and we had five shiny, new titles to show for it. Emma had put all that 'untested' bullshit to rest in crystal clear fashion, and Danni had buried the specter of that terrible loss and all the questions that went with it.

Best of all, I was in love. Totally and completely. Danni probably should have bounced me off a wall sooner because something about that moment had finally torn my emotions free. I didn't feel worthy of her. I never would. But suddenly it didn't matter. She wanted this. I wanted this. And now that I had it, I would do whatever it took to keep it.

So, I was in an incredibly good mood. Unlike anything I'd ever felt before. But poor Danni was still worried.

"You promised me," she said.

"I know I did, and I meant it," I said. "Nothing has changed, and nothing is going to."

"You sure?"

"Very. I'm just doing some thinking."

"About what?"

"You... me... what's going to happen later. I would give you more specifics, but I'm a respectable woman and I don't talk like that."

There was another brief pause.

"Wow," she breathed.

She paused again, and I was halfway hoping she would say she was skipping out too so we could finish what we'd started. But she couldn't. My absence might be notable, but hers would be glaring. You can't have a party without the guest of honor.

"What do I tell everyone?" she asked with a sigh of resignation.

"Tell them I'm fine, and that I'll see them at the hotel later tonight."

"You're not coming back?"

"No. You and I can't be in the same place until it's the right place. I think you know that."

"Yeah, I get it... but people are looking for you."

"They'll find me, eventually."

That brought another long pause.

"Danni, go," I said. "Enjoy your moment with your teammates."

"I want to enjoy it with you, too."

"You'll see me soon enough."

We hung up and I continued my destination-less journey. Realizing I was on the verge of meandering out of the business district, I turned south. My surroundings turned residential again within just a few blocks, but then I saw signage for something called *Kings Park*. It sounded like a good place to hide out for a while, so I stayed the course and was richly rewarded for my decision. With beautiful landscaping, intricate lighting and a thoroughly unbelievable view of the city, it turned out to be a good place to do just about anything. I had been there less than a minute before I found myself wishing there was a place like this for Danni and I to enjoy at home.

I smiled - not only at the thought, but at the ease with which it had come. I no longer had to think to include Danni in my plans because being with her WAS my plan.

With no intentions in mind, I spent a long time going in whatever direction my spirit moved me to go. I eventually found a grassy hillside that offered an unobstructed view, sat down and proceeded to do absolutely nothing. I stayed that way for a while, until my peace was disrupted by the ringing of my phone.

I knew before I looked who the caller would be.

"Where *ARE* you?" Danni asked again, with a considerable amount of irritation this time.

"Sitting on a hillside, looking down at the city and wishing you were here with me."

Sometimes honesty is the best policy, and the answer took the harshness right out of her tone.

"I'd like to be there, too," she said with a hint of amusement, "but you left without me."

"I did," I admitted. "We'll have to come back some time. Just the two of us."

"You'll forgive me if I say I'm not eager to visit Australia again anytime soon."

"Whenever," I said. "We've got time."

My new spirit of effusive positivity was apparently getting to be too much for her, and I could hear the smile in her response.

"I don't know what to do with you."

"I'm sure we can think of something."

That put a different sound in her voice.

"Either you stop talking like that, or get your ass back here so I can show you what I plan to do."

Hot damn.

"Where are you now?" I asked.

"Back at the hotel."

"Really? What time is it?"

"Almost midnight."

"Huh," I said. "I had no idea."

"You can't tell time?"

"I wasn't even trying."

Again, I heard the smile.

"You've lost your mind."

"Not yet, but it feels like I might be getting close."

I could picture her shaking her head and rolling her eyes. I still saw her smiling, though.

"How long do you think you'll be?" she asked.

I thought about that, realized I didn't know exactly where I was, and said, "I'm not sure."

"Are you lost?"

"Define *lost*."

"Richelle..."

"Relax. I'll figure it out. I'm on my way."

Using the stunning view to my advantage, I reasoned that the body of water to the right was probably Perth's famous Swan River. I sort of remembered where the hotel was in relation, so I made my way down and walked along the promenade. I pushed along for a while, unsure of exactly where I should cut north toward the city center. I made my move at William Street and found my way back to Wellington near a little glass-enclosed coffee shop called the *Tartine Cafe*. The decor and signage hinted at something interesting, but it was hard to judge because it was dark and closed. The late hour also meant there was no one to ask for directions, so I took a guess and turned right. I had only gone a few blocks when my phone rang again.

"Guess what I'm going to ask," Danni said.

"Hmm... where am I?"

"Wow, you got it on the first try."

"I'm on Wellington, but... wait, hold on a second."

I spotted train tracks to my left. Thinking they were likely the same tracks I'd seen earlier - and noting there was no stadium or tunnel in sight - I realized I had walked too far along the river. I was now east of both the arena and the hotel and getting further away.

"I made a wrong turn at Albuquerque," I said. "I got it now."

She stayed on the phone as I backtracked to the coffee shop, then went the other way. I found the hotel only a few blocks down.

I reported that I was no longer lost and was on my way up. My intention was to head straight for her room, but I didn't really get a choice because she was standing in the hallway waiting for me when I got off the elevator.

"I could kill you," she said.

"Kill me in your room," I said. "There'll be less witnesses."

We went in and she closed the door.

"Where have you..."

I grabbed two fistfuls of her shirt and pushed her back against the door. Then I kissed her, hard and deep. She resisted a bit out of surprise.

I broke the kiss, but didn't let her go.

"Now," I said, "where were we?"

There was no more talk after that.

We kissed again, and this time she melted right into it. Her lips were soft and warm against mine. She hooked an arm behind my back and held me close. I cupped the back of her head and pulled her deeper into the kiss. We nestled into each other. Slotted perfectly together like two pieces of a puzzle. Soon it was impossible to tell where one ended and the other began. I felt the curves and lines of her body pressed against mine. God... I wanted her so badly, and I could feel her hunger, as well. Which only made me want her more.

How things developed from there is something we'll never agree on. The way I remember it, her hand found its way under the hem of my blouse. She swears that was after I undid the button on her pants. Either way, the escalation was rapid and barely controlled. You've heard the song *Slow Hand*? Well, this wasn't anything like that. Once the first article of clothing came off, the process was continuous until not a thread stood between us, and it was all done with a rabid excitement that actually caused some damage.

Did I break the clasp on her bra?

Yes, I did.

Did she get tired of fumbling and simply tear my shirt open, sending buttons bouncing all around the room?

Yes, again.

The whole experience was clumsy, frantic and just a tiny bit savage. Driven by a ravenous need we had denied for too long and complicated by the fact that neither of us knew what the hell we were doing. Not only were we new to each other, but neither of us had ever been with another woman. It felt a little like wandering around the forest at night without a flashlight, but there isn't a single thing I would change if I could. It was our first time together, and that alone made it beautiful.

When we finished, we lay side-by-side on the bed, breathing like we'd just finished a marathon.

"So, I have a question," she said. "Do I have to win another tournament before we do this again?"

"Of course not," I said definitively. "Division and special event titles will do just fine."

She responded by punching me in the leg beneath the sheets.

"Ow," I said.

We laid there for a while, staring up at the ceiling. Then she rolled up on her side and I felt her finger trace a soft line across my shoulder and down my breastbone.

"Can I get you to do it again, right now?" she asked.

"Just say *please*."

Like she had to beg me to make love to her.

She wrinkled her nose and said, "No."

I kissed her anyway and it started all over again. We took it slower. The urgency was gone, and we spent a lot of time exploring each other. Learning how we liked to be touched and where. We would need many more moments like this before we got it perfect, but that was OK. Those moments were going to be there.

One thing I learned right away... being with another woman meant we only had to stop when we wanted to. And we really didn't want to.

By the time physical exhaustion forced us to take a break, a thin bar of sunlight was visible around the window shade.

"We forgot to sleep," I said.

"We'll have plenty of time to sleep on the plane."

"No, we won't."

A questioning look crossed her face, but there was a knock at the door before she could voice her thoughts.

She got up to see who it was, stopping to put on the complimentary robe along the way. I fumbled around for my pants and dug my phone out to check the time. Seven thirty, almost to the minute. The team plane was scheduled to leave at ten, which meant the visitor was likely an RSI early-riser.

I was willing to bet I knew which one, too.

Danni checked the peephole.

"It's Emma."

This should be fun.

Danni opened the door a few inches, stuck her head out and said, "Hey."

"I'm sorry," Emma said. "I know it's early, but I'm worried. We still can't find Richelle. No one's seen her since the press events."

Ever the diplomat, Danni tried a circumspect response.

"I'm sure she's fine," she said. "Did you check her room?"

"She's not answering," Em said, and I could hear the concern in her voice.

I appreciated what Danni was doing. We hadn't talked about how and when we were going to tell everyone about this, and she didn't feel comfortable making the decision for me. But we both knew the secret would be public knowledge before take-off, and a couple of hours of additional privacy didn't seem worth torturing anybody over.

I wrapped myself in the sheet, then walked over and touched my hand to Danni's back. She felt the question in the gesture, and answered by opening the door a little wider.

I peeked my head around her shoulder and said, "Hi, Em."

First came relief.

"Oh, thank god!"

Then came the anger.

"Hey! Where the hell have you been?"

Her fury was quickly interrupted by some vague notion that she was overlooking something important.

"I'm... so... oh."

Dr. Watson then took a moment to process the scene. The early hour. The bedsheet. The goofy smile on my face.

"Ohhhhh!" she exclaimed.

Ladies and gentlemen, we have cognition.

"Oh my god!" Emma cried. "Are you kidding me? You just... I mean... did you... well, yeah... of course, you did!"

"Jesus, Emma," I said, "get a grip."

"I'm sorry. It's just... you had us all worried. And now... are you kidding me? I'm so happy! I just want to hug you!"

"Maybe later," Danni said.

"When we have clothes on," I added.

"Right," Emma said. "Right, that's... yeah."

We all stood there smiling at each other for another moment. Long enough that it started to get awkward.

"Right... sorry," Emma said. "I didn't mean to interrupt. And don't worry, I won't say a thing to anybody."

I looked another question to Danni, and she smiled the answer back at me.

"Tell whoever you want," I said to Emma. "The world's worst-kept secret isn't a secret, anymore."

Emma and I may purposely annoy the shit out of each other, but the truth of our relationship was fully exposed by the inspired little happy dance she did there in the hallway.

"OK, go away," I said.

She did, but I heard her mumbling to herself along the way.

"*Did you check her room?* she asks me."

Danni closed the door and asked, "What do you mean we can't sleep on the plane?"

"I mean that we're not getting on the plane."

She smiled broadly before her natural instinct to bicker with me reasserted itself.

"You know, we can't turn every event into a private vacation."

"We've already been over this. I'm the boss. I can do whatever the fuck I want. Besides... we're not going to. But this feels like it deserves a few days of private celebration."

She got a wicked grin on her face as she pulled me close. Then she snaked her hand inside the sheet.

"I can think of a way to celebrate."

"You have a very dirty mind," I said.

Then I let the sheet fall to the floor as I reached up to slide the robe from her shoulders.